

users of their service. "If we know what they want and what they like, we can better fit into their online lives," they say. However, curiously enough, this data is also sold to advertisers who need targeted advertising. This information is also forwarded to marketers who can either choose to chase you now or later in the future. Does this mean social networks look at you as nothing but eyeballs to sell ads to? If Facebook is valued at \$18 billion and has just over 1 billion monthly active users, does that mean every Facebook user is worth \$18 as far as the social network is concerned? The answer to that is not so simple.

Advertising is a big part of the online economy. Without it, websites like Google, Facebook, Twitter and LinkedIn would shut down because they all use meta-data of their users for the purposes of targeted advertising, and for the most part users have gotten used to this fact by now. Some other websites and online services like Pandora – an online radio service provider – in addition to selling info for targeted advertising also sends it to marketers. Ad campaigns in Gmail and sponsored stories on Facebook and Twitter feeds are all based on the preferences social networks have determined their users have based on their likes, dislikes and activity history.

To data or not to data, that is the question

When Amazon or Flipkart tracks your browsing history within their websites, we know it's doing so to give you great recommendations and alert you to deals that might interest you. It's a win-win for both, the common netizen and big online



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–ERIC SCHMIDT
Executive Chairman, Google

it's through a browser window or via installed phone/tablet apps.

One of the major problems facing the Big Data mining industry is very simple to understand and comprehend. Just like huge swathes of Americans headed west once gold was discovered in California, and there was little or no semblance of law among early settlers, similarly, in the rush to mine more data of users (of which there's an unlimited supply) a number of apps are being pulled up for taking user data without the necessary permissions.

Take the example of Path, an app that got rave reviews and became very popular throughout 2012-13 before the

Rude shocks surrounding the (mis)use of Big Data abound on the interweb. Take the case of the retailer, Target Corp.'s analytics program which revealed a teenaged girl's impending pregnancy to her family, much to their distress and without the girl's consent. Similarly, an online travel agency called Orbitz was found guilty of up-charging Apple users after Big Data insights revealed that Apple customers were generally willing to pay more for travel. All such incidents heighten the tension around the positive use of Big Data analytics, giving users a glimpse into just how horribly wrong things could go if their metadata wasn't handled with care or was being used against them (despite assurances to the contrary).

There are other reasons for this growing atmosphere of mistrust. Users who are on social networks have little or no clue as to how they're being tracked and the magnitude of their tracking data. Also, since the entire concept of Big Data mining for business intelligence is so young and carefree, another major problem plaguing the system is a sense of wild wild west attitude: there's no industry self-regulation of analytics and social tracking on the interweb, nor (as far as we know) does the advertising industry's self-regulation allow you to opt out of social tracking – you can't just see a tracking-based ad and click a "do not track me in future" button on the ad, because there's none right now.

Last December, while talking about Big Data, Google's executive chairman, Eric Schmidt said, "The real issue is user-generated content," noting that pictures, instant messages, and tweets all add to this. But, he cautioned that major companies shouldn't do all sorts of things with user generated data, just because they can. While technology is neutral, Schmidt doesn't believe people are ready for what's coming. "I spend most of my time assuming the world is not ready for the technology revolution that will be happening to them soon," Schmidt said, according to a TechCrunch report. And for the most part, Schmidt's cautionary note is true.

If our handling of Big Data's past and present has been a complicated cesspool, its future surely promises to be an even more daunting task for us to deal with

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corporation. That's because users feel empowered and in control of their data being used for them and not necessarily against them.

However, the feeling is far from mutual when you're left to navigate the murky, muddled waters of social media, whether

party ended abruptly, as it was found to be downloading iPhone users' phone numbers without their explicit permission. Following this, upon reviewing several other apps of leading online services, a number of apps including Twitter were found to be doing the same.